

IT'S A HARD WORLD FOR LITTLE THINGS

THE NIGHT OF THE HUNTER / 1955

IN CONTEXT

GENRE

Thriller, horror

DIRECTOR

Charles Laughton

WRITERS

**James Agee (screenplay);
Davis Grubb (novel)**

STARS

**Robert Mitchum, Shelley
Winters, Lillian Gish**

BEFORE

1933 Charles Laughton wins an Oscar for the lead role in *The Private Life of Henry VIII*.

1947 Robert Mitchum makes his name in film noir with *Build My Gallows High*.

AFTER

1962 In *Cape Fear*, Mitchum again plays an ex-con who terrorizes a family, pitted against lawyer Gregory Peck.

Upon its release, *The Night of the Hunter* was such a critical and commercial failure that actor-turned-director Charles Laughton never directed another movie. The movie was marketed as, and appeared to be, a film noir, an idea reinforced by the casting of genre mainstay Robert Mitchum in the lead role. Yet it has more in common with 1920s German Expressionist horror movies than it does with hard-boiled noir,

with its use of exaggerated framing shots and shadow to create an escalating mood of dread. Contemporary audiences were, perhaps, confused when their expectations were confounded, but over time the movie has established itself as a key work of American cinema, a modern-day fairy tale unafraid of reveling in its darkness, both literally and figuratively.

Wolf in sheep's clothing

This is the story of a psychopath in preacher's clothing, Harry Powell (Mitchum), a con man who seduces and murders women. The action is set in the Great Depression, which has driven desperate family man Ben Harper to attempt a bank robbery. Harper is caught and sentenced to death for murdering two people during the robbery.

Powell shares a cell with Harper while Harper awaits execution. He learns that the condemned man has hidden \$10,000 with his family. On his release, Powell sets out to ingratiate himself with Harper's widow, Willa (Shelley Winters), and

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Charles finally had very little respect for [screenwriter] Agee. And he hated the script, but he was inspired by his hatred.

Elsa Lanchester
Charles Laughton's wife

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